According to the WHO, GM foods can also allow for reductions in food prices through improved yields and reliability. Farm activists in India don't agree with this assessment. India is a signatory to the Biosafety Protocol, adopted in Montreal, Canada, in 2000, which calls for national laws to regulate genetically modified organisms (GMOs). It includes the need for long-term studies before releasing GM crops, as their impact on the ecology is irreversible. So far, the pest-resistant Bt cotton is the only GM crop to be commercially introduced in India (in 2002).

This year, on October 18, the Genetic Engineering Appraisal Committee (GEAC)—India's apex regulator of GM foods—approved the environmental release of DMH-11. A week later, on October 25, the Bhupender Yadav-led ministry of environment, forest and climate change opened the doors for the agriculture ministry to carry out demonstration trials across five states, including Rajasthan, Punjab and Madhya Pradesh, before these genetically engineered mustard seeds could be commercially made available to farmers in India. Mustard, grown in the rabi season (October-March), is an important cash crop in north India, where oil extracted from its seeds is used for cooking, leaves consumed as a vegetable, and byproducts fed to the cattle.

For the past two decades, both the RSS affiliates and Left-leaning organisations have been opposing the introduction of GM crops in India. While the Left groups have been pursuing a legal battle in courts, the RSS affiliates have been putting pressure on PM Modi's regime against any such move since 2014. This time, the RSS affiliates have picked holes in the GEAC's findings itself. Earlier, in 2017 too, the regulatory body had cleared the introduction of GM mustard, but the process hit a roadblock. According to the saffron outfits opposed to the move, neither have additional tests been conducted in the past five years nor any question related to the safety and efficacy or the need for GM mustard been addressed by the government. A similar stance has been taken by social activist Aruna Rodrigues in her petition challenging the ministry's decision.

The key concerns that have been repeatedly raised by Sangh Parivar members are that GM crops make farmers dependent on seeds controlled by big foreign corporations and cause irreversible damage to the ecology. It was in light of this 'Swadeshi versus foreigner' debate and related concerns over food security that genetics scientist Deepak Pental led the development of DMH-11 at Delhi University in 2015. However, food safety activists and RSS affiliates reason that the hybrid variant is based on the same patented construct of a foreign firm (Proagro Seed Company—a subsidiary of Bayer) that had applied for the commercial approval of GM mustard in 2002. The Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) had rejected its application, stating that the field trials did not provide any evidence of a superior yield.

GOLD RUSH
The government claims GM mustard will lead to better yields; farm activists differ



GETTY IMAGES

AS THE BJP-RULED CENTRE MAKES A CASE FOR GENETICALLY MODIFIED MUSTARD, THE RSS AND ITS AFFILIATES OPPOSE THE MOVE

SJM co-convenor Ashwani Mahajan says that many food products from India get preferential treatment in international markets because of the 'non-GMO' tag. Thus, the introduction of GM crops will also hit food exports, he reasons. The saffron camp further holds that mustard has been grown in India since ancient times and is deeply integrated with our ecology—hence, no attempt should be made to disturb this delicate balance. The push for GM crops has also put minister Yadav in an awkward position, as the RSS affiliates have been citing articles he authored—before joining the government—that articulated the opposite view. Yadav has remained tight-lipped since the controversy broke, but is learnt to have been approaching the RSS bosses to share his ministry's point of view. The RSS leaders, however, maintain that the ball is in the PM's court now. "The prime minister is aware of the issue. And he understands our apprehensions. We are sure that he will take a decision that prioritises the interests of the country, farmers and food security," a senior RSS leader told INDIA TODAY on condition of anonymity.

Meanwhile, the BKS has decided to mobilise farmers on the issue, which has been added as an extra agenda in its mega rally planned in the national capital on December 19 to press for an increase in financial assistance under the PM Kisan scheme among other demands. For the BJP-led Centre—which is still feeling the residual anger of farmers who sat on a year-long agitation on Delhi's borders in 2020-21 against the now-repealed agricultural laws—this is the last thing they will want, and that too from an RSS affiliate. As the matter is now deliberated upon in court, the pressure from its own 'ideological cousins' is bound to keep the ruling party and its leaders on tenterhooks. ■